The Three Buckets

The Three Buckets is a simple sorting exercise I use in my Manifesto Workshop and Leadership Sprint. List about a dozen tasks you do in a typical week, sort each into one of the three buckets below, and over time shift your energy from Cut toward Amplify.

1 CUT Tasks AI can do now or soon

The efficiency work. Hand it to AI so you get your time back for the work that matters. Every hour saved here becomes an hour for Create or Amplify.

Examples: *first drafts, meeting notes, quick summaries, routine analysis, basic coding, scheduling, data cleanup*

Ask yourself:

- What do I do every week that feels mechanical?
- Which tasks drain me because they are tedious, not because they are hard?
- What could a capable assistant do with clear instructions?

2 CREATE New things you can do because of AI

The stretch work. AI makes the ceiling higher for everyone. Learn a skill you thought was out of reach, bridge an expertise gap, or take on a project that used to feel too big.

Examples: *build a prototype, learn a new field, ship an idea you could not ship alone, analyze something you never had time for*

Ask yourself:

- What have I wanted to build or learn but felt I lacked the time or skill?
- Where does my expertise stop, and could AI help bridge the gap?
- What project have I shelved because it felt too ambitious?

3 AMPLIFY What is uniquely you

The work only you can do. Deep judgment, complex relationships, original ideas, your distinct strengths. This is where the time you save lets you double down. No one beats you at being you.

Examples: *coaching a team member, closing a tough deal, making a hard call, shaping culture, telling your story*

Ask yourself:

- What work gives me energy instead of draining me?
- When do people tell me that only I could have done that?
- What would I never delegate, even to a trusted colleague?

Shift your energy from Cut toward Amplify. That is where the real value lives.

No one beats you at being you.